Review Article

Sport Sponsorship, Branding and Marketing: A Bibliometric Analysis Using VOSviewer

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Abstract

This review presents a bibliometric map of the sport sponsorship, branding and marketing literature indexed in Scopus between 2000 and 2026. A systematic search restricted to journal articles in the business, social science, economics and humanities subject areas returned 211 documents, authored by 506 researchers across 140 journals and accumulating 3,667 citations at the point of extraction. Five VOSviewer analyses, all using full counting, were used to map this corpus: co-authorship among authors, organisations and countries; co-occurrence of all keywords; and bibliographic coupling among documents. The co-authorship analyses revealed a fragmented field organised around small author teams and largely single-institution contributions, with the United States, United Kingdom and Australia dominating both output and citations. The keyword co-occurrence map showed a stable core vocabulary of sponsorship, sport, marketing and branding, flanked by a commercial and communicative cluster centred on advertising and social media and by a methodological and health-related cluster arising from the tobacco, alcohol and gambling literature indexed in biomedical journals. Bibliographic coupling confirmed this fragmentation at the level of citations: the most cited works, spanning influencer celebrification, celebrity endorsement, mega-event legacy and gambling convergence, share almost no common reference base with one another. Nearly half of the corpus has appeared since 2020, reflecting rapid expansion into esports, influencer marketing and athlete name, image and likeness rights. The findings indicate that sponsorship value depends on brand-property congruence and sustained relational alignment rather than exposure alone, and that regulated categories continue to use sport to reach audiences beyond the reach of direct advertising. The review concludes that the field would benefit from greater cross-national, longitudinal and theoretically integrative research.

Keywords: Sport sponsorship, Branding, Sport marketing, Social media, Bibliometric analysis, VOSviewer

Introduction

Sport sponsorship, branding and marketing has developed over the past three decades from a niche subfield of promotions management into a substantial and increasingly interdisciplinary area of scholarship. Early research treated sponsorship largely as a form of indirect advertising, concerned with the transfer of image from a sponsored property to a sponsoring brand and measured through recall, recognition and awareness metrics. This exposure-based paradigm assumed that value accrued more or less automatically from visibility, whether through stadium signage, kit branding or broadcast presence, and it dominated both academic enquiry and industry practice through the 1990s and 2000s.

That paradigm has since been substantially revised. A relationship-marketing perspective now treats sponsorship as an ongoing exchange between sponsor and sponsee, in which fit or congruence between

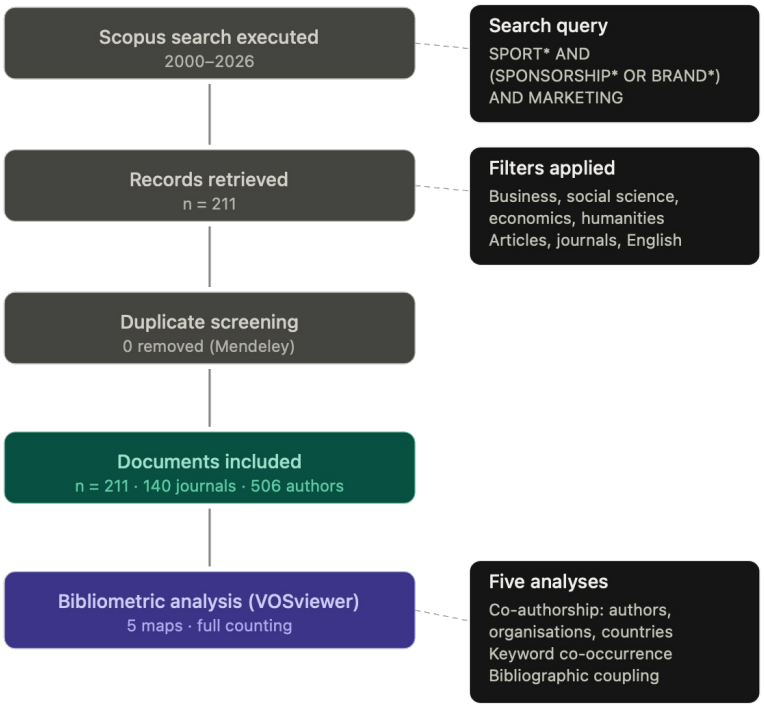
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brand and property, the strength of interpersonal and inter-organisational ties, and continuity over time matter more than raw exposure. This shift has been reinforced by the emergence of social and digital media as commercial platforms in their own right: clubs, athletes and leagues now generate branded content directly, sponsors activate partnerships through influencers and athlete endorsers, and entirely new commercial ecosystems, most notably esports and fantasy and betting platforms, have arisen alongside traditional sport. Sponsorship research has therefore had to extend beyond the sponsor-property dyad to account for audiences, platforms and intermediaries that did not exist when the field's foundational studies were written.

A further strand of this literature is regulatory rather than commercial in origin. Because direct advertising of tobacco, alcohol and, in many jurisdictions, gambling products is restricted or prohibited, sport sponsorship has repeatedly been used by firms in these categories as an alternative channel through which to build and sustain brand associations. This has drawn public health and policy researchers into a literature otherwise dominated by marketing and management scholars, producing a body of work that is simultaneously commercial and epidemiological in character and that raises distinct questions of consumer protection and regulatory design.

Given the pace at which the field has grown, particularly since 2020, and the range of disciplines now contributing to it, a systematic bibliometric map of the literature is timely. This review draws on VOSviewer to characterise the collaborative structure, geographical distribution and conceptual organisation of 211 journal articles published between 2000 and 2026, in order to establish where the field currently stands and where its research effort might most usefully be directed next.

Figure 1. Search and selection process



Importance of the study

A systematic map of this literature has practical value for several distinct audiences. For sport marketers and rights holders, it identifies which mechanisms of sponsorship value, such as brand-property congruence and relational continuity, are best supported by evidence, and which commercial territories, including esports, influencer marketing and athlete name, image and likeness rights, are expanding fastest and therefore warrant closer attention. For sponsors and their agencies, the review clarifies how audiences actually process sponsorship-related brand associations across traditional and social media platforms, informing decisions about where and how sponsorship investment is best deployed.

For regulators and public health bodies, the review draws together, in one place, the evidence on how tobacco, alcohol and gambling firms have used sport sponsorship to sustain brand-building activity in the presence of direct-advertising restrictions, which is directly relevant to ongoing debates about the scope and enforcement of such restrictions. For researchers, the bibliometric analyses expose the current field's structural weaknesses, including its reliance on small, loosely connected author teams, its concentration in a handful of Anglophone countries, and the near-absence of citation links between its most influential studies, thereby identifying concrete opportunities for more integrative and internationally collaborative research programmes.

Methodology

Information on the topic “sport sponsorship, branding and marketing” was searched for upon the Scopus database on 21st may 2026. The data was taken from 2000-2026. The articles had been searched for upon the Scopus database using the query (TITLE-ABS-KEY (SPORT* AND (“SPONSORSHIP*” OR “BRAND*”) AND MARKETING)) from 2000 to 2026, with filters applied for the subject areas of business, management and accounting (BUSI), social sciences (SOCI), economics, econometrics and finance (ECON) and arts and humanities (ARTS). Additional filters applied were for the document type article, the source type journal, and for the inclusion of the English language. A total of 211 documents appeared following this query, and zero duplicates were found after screening for duplicates using Mendeley. The dataset obtained was exported to the VOSviewer software for visualization and bibliometric analysis.

The retrieved corpus comprises 211 journal articles published between 2000 and 2026, distributed across 140 distinct source titles and authored by 506 unique researchers, with a mean of 2.70 authors per article and 40 single-authored contributions. The corpus had accumulated 3,667 citations at the point of extraction, giving a mean of 17.4 and a median of 7 citations per document, while 31 articles remained uncited. Output is strongly weighted toward the recent period: 54 articles were published between 2000 and 2014, 53 between 2015 and 2019, and 104 from 2020 onwards, meaning that almost half of the corpus (49.3%) appeared in the final seven years of the window.

Five bibliometric analyses were then performed in VOSviewer using the full counting method. Co-authorship was examined with three separate units of analysis i.e authors, organisations and countries in order to establish the collaborative structure of the field at the individual, institutional and national levels. Co-occurrence analysis was performed on all keywords, combining author-supplied and Scopus index terms, to identify the conceptual structure of the literature. Finally, bibliographic coupling with documents as the unit of analysis was used to establish the extent to which the most cited studies draw on a shared intellectual base. The specific occurrence, document and citation thresholds applied within each analysis are

reported at the start of the corresponding section below. For each analysis, the resulting network map is presented as a figure and the items meeting the thresholds are reported in an accompanying table showing document counts, citation counts and total link strength.

Table 1. Keywords employed in the literature search and the number of results from Scopus database

Keywords	**Scopus**
SPORT* AND (“SPONSORSHIP*” OR “BRAND*”) AND MARKETING	211
Duplicates	0
Total (net of duplicates)	211

Co-authorship and authors

On the basis of co-authorship with the unit of analysis being authors, the minimum number of documents by an author was set to 2 and the minimum number of citations of an author was set to 14. Out of a total of 506 authors, 12 met the thresholds. The most cited authors were Bradley J. Baker and Jason P. Doyle (220 citations each), followed by Christos Anagnostopoulos (184 citations) and Sarah Jane Kelly (165 citations). Janice Hemmonsbey was the most prolific author in the set with 4 documents, followed by Anagnostopoulos and Ashlee Morgan with 3 each. A notable feature of this map is the low total link strength across the field: five of the twelve authors record a total link strength of zero, and the highest value observed is 3. Co-authorship in this literature is therefore organised around small, largely self-contained author teams rather than an integrated collaborative network.

Figure 2. Co-authorship and authors visualization

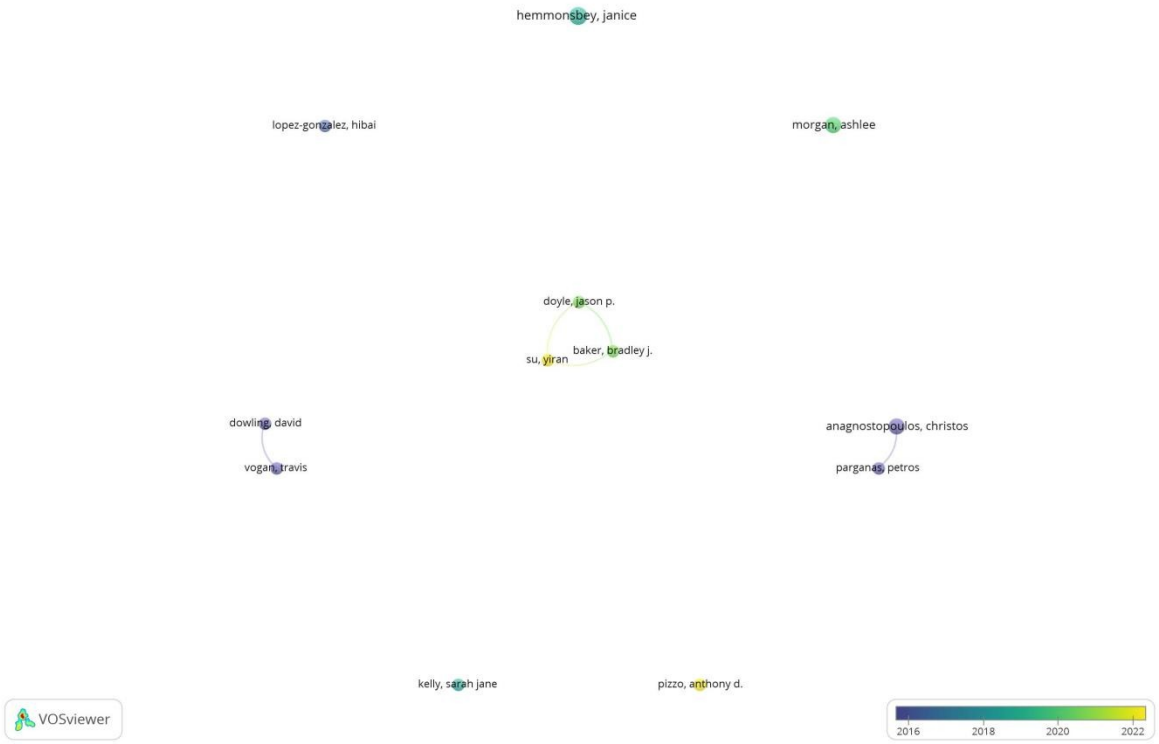


Table 2. Co-authorship and authors

Author	Documents	Citations	Total Link Strength
Baker, Bradley J.	2	220	3
Doyle, Jason P.	2	220	3
Anagnostopoulos, Christos	3	184	2
Kelly, Sarah Jane	2	165	0
Su, Yiran	2	147	2
Lopez-Gonzalez, Hibai	2	136	0
Parganas, Petros	2	136	2
Morgan, Ashlee	3	116	0
Hemmonsbey, Janice	4	112	0
Pizzo, Anthony D.	2	93	0
Dowling, David	2	82	2
Vogan, Travis	2	82	2

Athletes' TikTok content during the COVID-19 shutdown was playful and informal, and that lack of polish was read by audiences as authentic. The platform worked as a relationship-maintenance tool: sustaining bonds with existing fans, embedding branded content in entertaining formats, and reaching new fan segments beyond conventional highlights and interviews (Su et al., 2020). Mapping a football club's tweeted brand attributes against replies, retweets and favourites showed that product-related and non-product-related attributes generate unequal engagement. Social media therefore does not simply distribute a brand — it determines which brand associations followers actually adopt (Parganas et al., 2015). ESPN used Grantland.com and its print spin-off to borrow the prestige of literary magazines and canonical sportswriting. By attaching itself to long-form journalism and established print writers, it manufactured highbrow credibility that widened its demographic reach and reinforced its dominant institutional identity (Vogan & Dowling, 2016). Across 403 surveys and 24 stakeholder interviews, climate, exchange rates and natural scenery emerged as South Africa's strongest destination brand associations, while safety perceptions and weak on-site branding were the constraints. Both constraints depend on public–private investment, positioning event and destination as co-brands (Hemmonsbey & Tichaawa, 2020).

Among 501 university sportspeople, a third received alcohol sponsorship, and the type mattered more than its presence: direct-to-user inducements such as samples, vouchers and prizes were associated with problematic consumption. The authors recommend targeting these specific mechanisms and team culture rather than a blanket ban (Kelly et al., 2014). Viewed through economic convergence, online betting has become the connective tissue linking esports, fantasy sports, social gaming, data markets, sport media and sponsorship. Gambling is progressively absorbing other entertainment forms, expanding commercial reach while blurring the line between watching and wagering (Lopez-Gonzalez & Griffiths, 2018). Examined from the sponsee's side rather than the sponsor's, relational effectiveness at a major event rested on three attributes: strategic alignment, a constructive inter-organisational culture supported by strong interpersonal

ties, and stability over time. Sponsorship functions as an ongoing brand alliance, not a transaction (Morgan et al., 2020). Network analysis of the NBA, NBA 2K League and LCS portfolios found the 2K League's sponsors to be deliberately hybrid, drawn from both traditional sport and endemic esports categories. This mixed portfolio legitimises a boundary-spanning product across physical and virtual domains simultaneously (Lopez et al., 2021).

Co-authorship and organisations

On the basis of co-authorship with the unit of analysis being organisations, the minimum number of documents of an organisation was set to 1 and the minimum number of citations of an organisation was set to 56. Out of a total of 408 organisations, 38 met the thresholds, of which the 14 most cited are reported below. The most cited institutions were the International Institute for Management Development in Lausanne, King's College London and Loyola University Chicago (176 citations each), reflecting their joint contribution to the single most cited paper in the corpus. Only the School of Sport, Tourism and Hospitality Management at Temple University contributed more than one document. The institutional map is therefore dominated by universities in the United States, Australia and the United Kingdom, and its links are almost entirely artefacts of individual co-authored papers rather than sustained inter-institutional programmes.

Drawing on interviews with 40 advertising practitioners and influencers, the study theorises influencer celebrification — the process by which social media influencers accumulate celebrity capital without the traditional gatekeepers of sport, film or television. Three practice types drive it: generative, collaborative and evaluative, with advertising practitioners themselves active in conferring status (Brooks et al., 2021). A survey of 382 US sports-drink consumers, analysed via structural equation modelling, found that endorser credibility raises brand equity through two routes: a direct effect strengthened when consumers perceive endorser–brand congruence, and an indirect path partly mediated by self-brand connection. Celebrities thus operate at the level of consumer self-concept, not merely awareness (Dwivedi et al., 2015). Scraping Twitter and Instagram profiles of collegiate athletes and applying influencer-marketing rate cards, the authors demonstrated that student-athletes hold measurable name, image and likeness value. That value is related to the institution but not generated solely by it, which has direct implications for NCAA and conference-level policy (Kunkel et al., 2021). A systematic narrative review of mega-event research found that social impacts — skills, destination branding, cohesion, sustainability, sport development — are recognised but inconsistently defined and measured, with costs under-examined relative to benefits. The review is the first to assess social-impact evaluation itself and closes with a research agenda for bid cases and legacy assessment (Mair et al., 2023).

Co-authorship and countries

On the basis of co-authorship with the unit of analysis being countries, the minimum number of documents of a country was set to 2 and the minimum number of citations of a country was set to 1. Out of a total of 52 countries, 28 met the thresholds, of which the 11 most productive are reported below. The United States stands out with by far the highest number of documents (72) and citations (1,497), as well as the highest total link strength (23). It is followed by the United Kingdom (29 documents, 798 citations) and Australia (23 documents, 953 citations), with Australia achieving a markedly higher citation-per-document ratio than either. Canada (14 documents) forms a fourth substantial contributor, while South Korea, Spain, China, South Africa, France, Cyprus and Switzerland contribute smaller but non-trivial bodies of work. The

distribution is therefore strongly Anglophone: the four leading countries account for the large majority of both output and impact, and research from Asia, Latin America and Africa remains comparatively sparse.

Figure 3. Co-authorship and organisations visualization



Comparing JSE-listed firms that sponsored sport consistently between 2000 and 2015 against those that did not, sponsors showed no advantage in share price or revenue growth, but did achieve significantly higher earnings-per-share growth. Only consumer services saw revenue gains, and those did not convert to profit — suggesting sponsorship serves objectives other than direct sales (Blake et al., 2019). A content analysis of 1,473 FTSE100 annual reports, reviews and CSR reports across 2003–2012 traced how firms use sport within their CSR agendas. Three streams emerged — philanthropy, sponsorship and personnel engagement — with philanthropy growing most slowly, and overall CSR-through-sport activity rising across the decade (Bason & Anagnostopoulos, 2015). Using the Export A brand's sponsorship of extreme sports events in Canada as a case, the authors show how tobacco firms deployed classical conditioning to build brand associations that circumvented tightening advertising restrictions. The paper closes by questioning whether such sponsorship retains value once the sport–brand association can no longer be refreshed (Vredenburg et al., 2015).

This lead article to a special issue argues that the rapid expansion of China's sport industry has outpaced the applicability of Western theory, since social, cultural, historical and governmental differences limit direct transfer of established best practice. The authors identify a shortage of empirical evidence on Chinese sport business and set out priorities for transnational firms operating there and Chinese firms going global (Liu et al., 2017). Adapting an established sponsorship model to esports, the study found that non-endemic sponsors do benefit — through improved attitudes, perceived goodwill and purchase intentions — despite

esports audiences' reputation for hostility toward outside brands. Esports brand attitude had only a weak effect on attitude toward the sponsor but a stronger one on goodwill and purchase intent, making low-cost team sponsorships attractive to smaller advertisers (Huettermann et al., 2023).

Table 3. Co-authorship and organisations

Organisation	**Documents**	**Citations**	**Total Link Strength**
International Institute for Management Development, Lausanne, Switzerland	1	176	2
King's College London, London, United Kingdom	1	176	2
Loyola University Chicago, Chicago, IL, United States	1	176	2
School of Management and Marketing, Charles Sturt University, Albury, Australia	1	165	2
Swinburne University of Technology, Hawthorne, Australia	1	165	2
Texas Tech University, Lubbock, TX, United States	1	165	2
UQ Business School, The University of Queensland, Brisbane, QLD, Australia	1	151	0
Dept. of Kinesiology, University of Georgia, Athens, GA, United States	1	147	2
Dept. of Tourism, Sport and Hotel Management, Griffith University, Nathan, QLD, Australia	1	147	2
Mark H. McCormack Dept. of Sport Management, University of Massachusetts Amherst, MA, United States	1	147	2
School of Sport, Tourism and Hospitality Management, Temple University, Philadelphia, PA, United States	2	133	0
Edinburgh Business School, Heriot-Watt University, United Kingdom	1	117	2
Molde University College, University of Central Lancashire, Cyprus	1	117	2
Sport Business Strategy and Marketing, Coventry University Business School, United Kingdom	1	117	2

Figure 4. Co-authorship and countries visualization

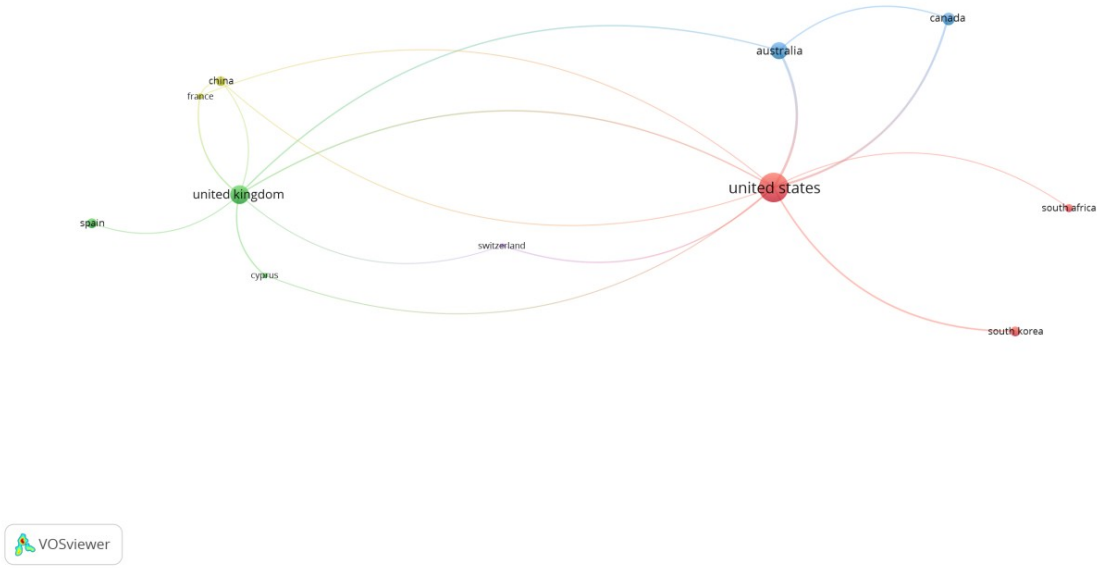


Table 4. Co-authorship and countries

Country	**Documents**	**Citations**	**Total Link Strength**
United States	72	1497	23
Australia	23	953	11
United Kingdom	29	798	11
Canada	14	379	7
Spain	8	241	1
Switzerland	2	236	3
Cyprus	3	169	3
France	4	151	4
South Africa	6	145	1
China	8	137	3
South Korea	9	113	3

Co-occurrence and keywords

On the basis of co-occurrence with the unit of analysis being all keywords, combining author-supplied and Scopus index terms, the minimum number of occurrences of a keyword was set to 5. Out of a total of 1,033 keywords, 33 met the threshold, of which the 12 most frequent are reported below. The most frequently occurring keyword was “sponsorship” (34 occurrences), closely followed by “sport” (33) and “marketing” (27), with “branding” (25) and “sports” (19) completing the core vocabulary of the field. Beneath this core sit two distinguishable groups. The first is commercial and communicative, comprising “advertising” (14), “social media” (10), “sport sponsorship” (10) and “football” (9), and it reflects the platform- and property-specific strand of the literature. The second is methodological and health-related, comprising the Scopus index terms “human” (20), “article” (16) and “humans” (12), which enter the map through the tobacco, alcohol and gambling studies indexed in biomedical journals. The presence of both groups within a single map indicates that this literature is written simultaneously for a marketing readership and for a public health readership, and that these two audiences share a common object of study but relatively little common terminology.

An audit of 34 no- and low-alcohol beer brands found 13 holding Australian sport sponsorship, and a content analysis of 118 associated social media posts identified activation, occasion-specific drinking cues, influence marketing, competitions and CSR framing as the dominant tactics. Brands positioned these products as healthy “sports beers” to enter the sports drink market, while escaping alcohol regulation by being classified as soft drinks (Miller & Wright, 2024). Analysing over 90,000 press photographs and 51 match videos of LED boarding at UEFA EURO 2020, the authors found that five of the twelve official sponsors altered their activation mid-tournament to signal support for diversity and inclusion. Positioning varied systematically with the geographical, social and political context of each match, showing that sponsors calibrate social-justice messaging by market rather than applying it globally (Beek et al., 2023).

Bibliographic coupling and documents

On the basis of bibliographic coupling with the unit of analysis being documents, the minimum number of citations of a document was set to 4. Out of a total of 211 documents, 32 met the threshold, of which the 8 most cited are reported below. Brooks (2021) is the most cited document in the corpus with 176 citations, followed by Dwivedi (2015) with 165 and Mair (2023) with 151. The defining feature of this analysis is how weakly these documents are coupled: total link strength ranges only from 0 to 3, and three of the eight most cited works share no coupling links at all with the remainder of the set. The most cited studies in this field therefore draw on largely separate reference bases — celebrity endorsement and influencer research, sponsorship-linked marketing, event legacy evaluation, gambling convergence and gender in professional gaming each cite their own parent literatures. Bibliographic coupling thus confirms at the level of citations what the co-authorship analyses showed at the level of collaboration: this is a thematically coherent but intellectually fragmented field, integrated by its object of study rather than by a shared theoretical canon.

An event study of share-price movements around Indianapolis 500 sponsorships tested whether winning, or merely participating, creates firm value. Sponsors whose products had a logical fit with the consumer automotive industry recorded statistically and economically significant share-price gains around victories, while sponsors without that product congruence gained little — establishing fit, not exposure alone, as the driver of returns (Cornwell et al., 2001). Athletes’ TikTok content during the COVID-19 shutdown was playful and informal, and that lack of polish was read by audiences as authentic. The platform worked as a relationship-maintenance tool — sustaining existing fan bonds, embedding branded content in entertaining

formats, and reaching new fan segments beyond conventional highlights and interviews (Su et al., 2020). Viewed through economic convergence, online betting has become the connective tissue linking esports, fantasy sports, social gaming, data markets, sport media and sponsorship. Gambling is progressively absorbing other entertainment forms, expanding commercial reach while blurring the line between watching sport and wagering on it (Lopez-Gonzalez & Griffiths, 2018). This study maps the roles women occupy in North American professional gaming — mothers supporting competing sons, female competitors, and promotional models staffing sponsor booths. Each role is precariously held within a community that reads female participation in sexualised terms, so that women's varied labour is collapsed into a narrow set of gendered categories in a space framed as male territory (Taylor et al., 2009).

Results

Read together, the five analyses describe a field that has grown rapidly but has not consolidated. The temporal distribution of the corpus shows that output has accelerated sharply in recent years: only 54 of the 211 articles were published between 2000 and 2014, compared with 53 between 2015 and 2019 and 104 from 2020 onwards, so that almost half of all output (49.3%) has appeared within the final seven years of the search window. This acceleration coincides with the emergence of the social media, esports and influencer-marketing themes that recur throughout the co-authorship and keyword analyses, suggesting that the recent growth of the field is substantially driven by these newer commercial forms rather than by continued output on traditional sponsorship arrangements.

Figure 5. Co-occurrence and keywords visualization

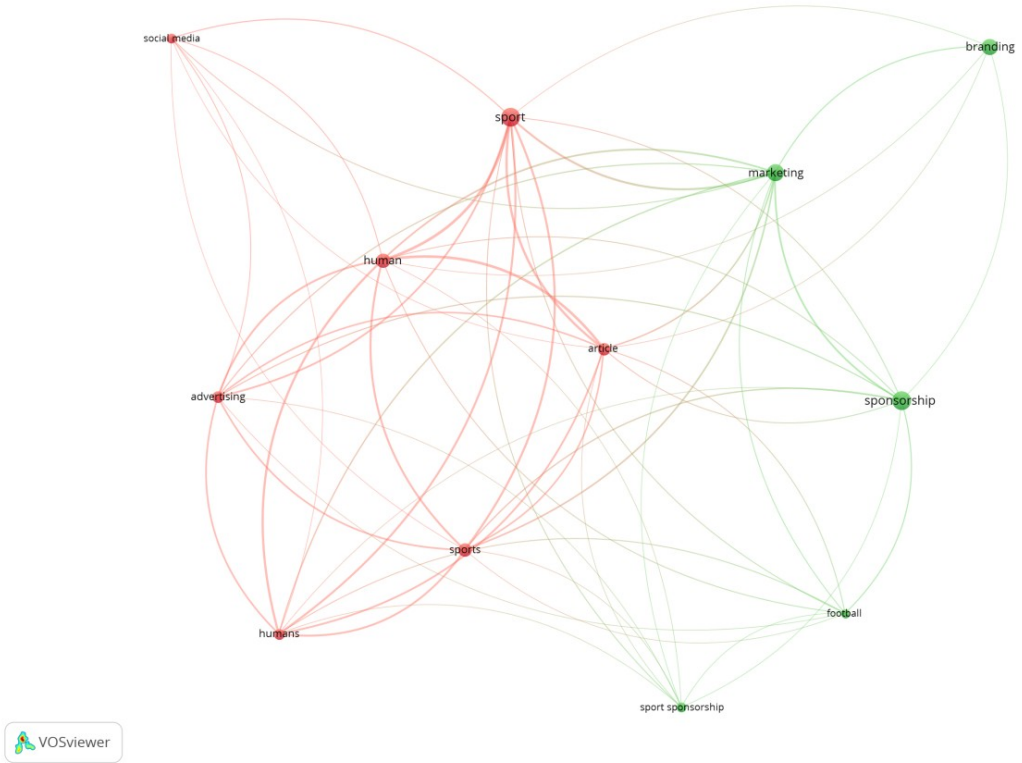


Table 5. Co-occurrence and keywords

S. No.	Keyword	Occurrences	Total Link Strength
1	Sponsorship	34	26
2	Sport	33	79
3	Marketing	27	50
4	Branding	25	7
5	Human	20	79
6	Sports	19	56
7	Article	16	61
8	Advertising	14	47
9	Humans	12	55
10	Social media	10	12
11	Sport sponsorship	10	10
12	Football	9	16

Geographically, the co-authorship analysis by country shows output concentrated overwhelmingly in a small number of Anglophone nations. The United States leads by a wide margin on documents (72), citations (1,497) and total link strength (23), followed by the United Kingdom and Australia; Australia records a markedly higher citation-per-document ratio than either of the other two leading countries, indicating a smaller but more consistently influential body of national work. Canada forms a fourth substantial contributor, while South Korea, Spain, China, South Africa, France, Cyprus and Switzerland each contribute smaller, single-country bodies of research. Contributions from Asia, Latin America and Africa remain comparatively sparse and are concentrated in individual case studies, such as the South African tourism-branding and corporate-sponsorship work and the commentary on the Chinese sport industry, rather than in comparative or cross-national designs.

At the author and organisational level, the co-authorship analyses point to a field organised around small, largely self-contained teams rather than an integrated collaborative network. Only 12 of 506 authors and 38 of 408 organisations met even the modest thresholds applied, and total link strength rarely exceeded 3 at either level, with several high-citation authors and institutions recording no co-authorship links outside their own paper. The organisational map is further shaped by the fact that most linked institutions co-occur only because they jointly authored a single highly cited paper, rather than because of a sustained institutional partnership, and the map is dominated by universities in the United States, Australia and the United Kingdom, consistent with the country-level pattern.

The keyword co-occurrence analysis identifies a stable conceptual core, comprising sponsorship, sport, marketing and branding, surrounded by two distinguishable groups of terms. A commercial and communicative group, including advertising, social media, sport sponsorship and football, reflects the platform- and property-specific strand of the literature discussed above. A second, methodological and

health-related group, comprising the Scopus index terms human, article and humans, enters the map primarily through the tobacco, alcohol and gambling studies that are indexed in biomedical as well as management journals. The co-presence of these two vocabularies in a single map indicates that the field is written simultaneously for a marketing readership and a public health readership, which share an object of study but relatively little common terminology.

Figure 6. Bibliographic coupling and documents visualization

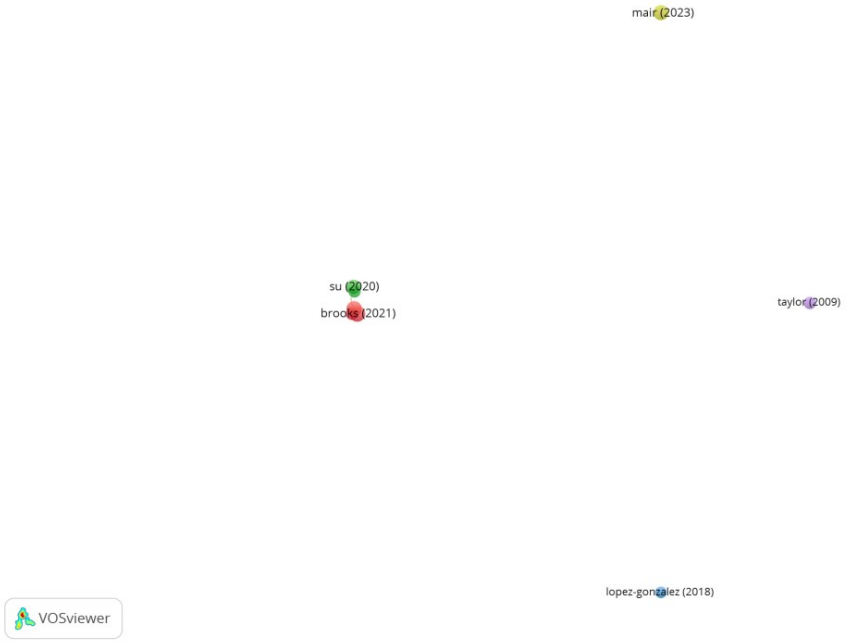


Table 6. Bibliographic coupling and documents

Document	**Citations**	**Total Link Strength**
Brooks (2021)	176	1
Dwivedi (2015)	165	3
Mair (2023)	151	0
Su (2020)	147	1
Parganas (2015)	117	2
Cornwell (2001)	113	1
Taylor (2009)	103	0
Lopez-Gonzalez (2018)	97	0

Finally, the bibliographic coupling analysis shows that the most cited documents in the corpus are only weakly connected to one another at the level of shared references, with total link strength ranging from 0 to 3 among the eight most cited works and three of those eight sharing no coupling links with the remainder of the set at all. The most influential studies in the field, covering influencer celebrification, celebrity

endorsement, mega-event legacy, athlete-led social media, sponsorship-linked marketing and gender in professional gaming, therefore draw on largely separate parent literatures. Taken together with the co-authorship findings, this indicates that the field is thematically coherent, in that its authors study a recognisably common set of phenomena, but intellectually fragmented, in that its most influential contributions do not build on a shared theoretical canon.

Implications for researchers

For researchers, the most direct implication of this review is that the field's rapid recent growth has outpaced its theoretical consolidation. Because the most cited studies are only weakly bibliographically coupled, researchers entering newer commercial territories such as esports sponsorship, influencer celebrification or athlete name, image and likeness rights have comparatively little shared theoretical infrastructure to build on, and would benefit from explicitly testing whether constructs developed for traditional sponsorship, such as brand-property congruence and relationship continuity, transfer to these settings or require new theorisation.

The geographical concentration of both output and collaboration in the United States, United Kingdom and Australia is a second clear gap. Because sponsorship effectiveness depends on cultural and regulatory context, findings established in these three countries cannot safely be assumed to generalise to the rapidly growing sport economies of Asia, Africa and Latin America, where sponsorship, media and regulatory conditions differ substantially. Cross-national and comparative designs, rather than further single-country case studies, are needed to establish the boundary conditions of existing theory.

The weakness of the collaborative network at author and institutional level also points to a methodological opportunity. With total link strength rarely exceeding 3 even among the most cited authors and institutions, there is considerable scope for larger, multi-site collaborative projects, longitudinal designs that track sponsorship relationships and brand associations over time, and shared datasets or replications that would allow findings to accumulate across research groups rather than remaining confined to isolated teams.

Finally, the co-occurrence of a commercial-communicative vocabulary with a methodological and health-related vocabulary indicates that this field is read by two audiences, marketing scholars and public health researchers, that currently share relatively little common terminology. Researchers working on regulated categories such as alcohol, tobacco and gambling sponsorship would benefit from more deliberately bridging these vocabularies, so that findings on regulatory circumvention and consumer harm are expressed in terms that are legible to, and cited by, mainstream sponsorship and branding researchers, and vice versa.

Practical implications

For rights holders and sponsors, the evidence assembled here indicates that sponsorship value is generated primarily through fit and sustained relational alignment rather than through exposure alone. Sponsorship programmes are therefore best evaluated, and structured, around the strength of brand-property congruence, the quality of the working relationship between sponsor and sponsee, and continuity over multiple cycles, rather than around reach or impression counts. The social media evidence further suggests that rights holders should treat their own platforms and athletes' personal channels as active determinants of which brand associations audiences adopt, not simply as additional distribution channels for content produced elsewhere.

For athletes, and particularly student-athletes and esports competitors, the review's evidence on name, image and likeness value and on athlete-led social media indicates that personal digital channels now carry measurable commercial value independent of, though related to, an athlete's team or institution. Athletes and their advisors are therefore well placed to negotiate sponsorship and endorsement arrangements that reflect this direct audience relationship, rather than treating such value as fully captured by team- or league-level sponsorship deals.

For regulators and public health bodies, the recurring finding that tobacco, alcohol and gambling firms use sport sponsorship to sustain brand-building activity where direct advertising is restricted has a clear policy implication: restrictions confined to conventional advertising channels are likely to be at least partly circumvented through sponsorship-based brand association unless sponsorship itself is addressed, whether through direct restriction, disclosure requirements, or scrutiny of specific high-risk mechanisms such as direct-to-consumer sampling and inducements.

More broadly, sponsors, rights holders and regulators operating in the newer commercial territories mapped by this review, including esports, no- and low-alcohol beverage sponsorship, and social-justice positioning, should treat these as areas in which practice is evolving faster than either academic evidence or regulatory frameworks, and should correspondingly build in mechanisms for ongoing evaluation rather than assuming that norms established in traditional sponsorship contexts will transfer without modification.

Conclusion

This review shows how research on sport sponsorship, branding and marketing has evolved with regards to geographical distribution, collaborative structure and conceptual focus. The co-authorship analyses revealed a field that is productive but structurally thin: of 506 authors and 408 organisations in the corpus, only 12 authors and 38 institutions met even modest thresholds, and total link strength rarely exceeded 3 at either level. Output is heavily concentrated in the United States, the United Kingdom and Australia, which together account for the large majority of documents and citations, while contributions from Asia, Africa and Latin America remain limited and are usually framed as single-country case studies rather than comparative work. The co-occurrence analysis showed a stable core vocabulary organised around sponsorship, sport, marketing and branding, flanked on one side by a platform- and property-specific commercial strand and on the other by an epidemiological strand carried into the map by the tobacco, alcohol and gambling literature.

The bibliographic coupling analysis reinforced this picture. The most cited works in the corpus — spanning influencer celebrification, celebrity endorsement, mega-event legacy, athlete-led social media, sponsorship-linked marketing and gender in professional gaming — are almost entirely uncoupled from one another, indicating that they draw on separate parent literatures and accumulate influence independently. Read alongside the temporal distribution, in which almost half of all output has appeared since 2020, this suggests a field that is expanding rapidly into new commercial terrain, particularly esports, influencer marketing and athlete name, image and likeness rights, faster than it is consolidating a shared theoretical base. The substantive findings themselves point in a consistent direction: sponsorship value depends on congruence and sustained relational alignment rather than exposure alone, social platforms determine which brand associations audiences actually adopt, and regulated categories continue to use sport to reach audiences that direct advertising rules would otherwise place beyond reach.

Future research should therefore prioritise integration over further fragmentation. Cross-national and longitudinal designs are needed to establish whether sponsorship effects documented in Anglophone markets hold in the rapidly growing sport economies of Asia, Africa and Latin America. Comparative work linking traditional, esports and influencer sponsorship within a single analytical framework would help determine whether these are variants of one mechanism or genuinely distinct phenomena. Sustained attention is also required to the regulatory frontier, where no- and low-alcohol brands, gambling operators and social-justice positioning are reshaping what sponsorship communicates and to whom. Overall, building stronger international collaborations and a more integrated evidence base is essential for producing sport sponsorship research that reflects diverse markets, improves policy relevance, and supports more accountable commercial practice for rights holders, sponsors, athletes and audiences alike.

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